

CHAPTER 4

Burdens

One of the most important discoveries of IFS is that extreme parts who appear irrationally self-destructive and aggressive are not what they appear to be. Instead, extreme parts have a rationale for their behavior and they feel driven to extremity by beliefs, emotions, and energies that enter our systems from trauma or attachment injury; additionally, these beliefs, emotions, and energies can be inherited from family, ethnic group, or culture. We call extreme beliefs, emotions, and energies that enter through direct life experience *personal burdens*. We call the ones that were absorbed from family, ethnic group, or culture *legacy burdens*.

The importance of distinguishing between parts (who are valuable) and their burdens (which need to be unloaded) cannot be overemphasized. Most psychotherapies and spiritual traditions mistake parts for their burdens and, consequently, go to great lengths to try to throw the baby out with the bathwater. From the IFS perspective, for example, our brutal inner critic isn't merely grandmother's internalized critical voice that we need to drown out or expel. Instead, it's an 8-year-old who is using Grandmother's shaming voice, image, and energy in a desperate attempt to prevent further injury. When the 8-year-old critic trusts that it's safe to unburden—to release that shaming energy out of the inner system—it will transform. In this chapter we look at how burdened protectors polarize each other, inhibiting or disinhibiting and becoming ever more extreme, while burdened exiles threaten inner stability with their sadness, loneliness, and despair.

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FORMATIVE ENVIRONMENTS

Culture is formative for children. Mainstream culture in the United States influences families to favor children who show ambition and independence while disdaining children who seem easily hurt

and dependent. A patriarchal culture gives males more deference, resources, influence, and responsibility than females of a similar age or role. A racist culture gives one racial group more deference, resources, influence, and responsibility than others. Cultural biases like individualism, patriarchy, and racism are burdens that throw families and cultures profoundly off balance. (For more on how these cultural burdens affect the United States, see [Chapter 18](#).)

In IFS we explore how burdens are passed down generations by parents valuing or rejecting certain of their own parts, and then doing the same to their children (and others), teaching them to value or reject these kinds of parts internally. For example, let's say a mother, whose dominant manager focuses on pleasing others, shames her daughter whenever she expresses anger. As a result, the daughter develops a manager who worries about approval and works to silence her assertive parts. Her approval-seeking part is getting too much responsibility, influence, and access to resources, while her assertive parts get too little. This is the product of the over-pleasing legacy burden. This burden may have arisen initially from the travails of her immigrant ancestors generations earlier.

THE NATURE OF A LEGACY BURDEN

When Joe (or anyone) is anxious, we will relate to him the way we relate to our own anxious parts. This is an important law of what I call *inner physics*. If you hate your vulnerability, you will punish your son when he is vulnerable. If you fear your anger, you will either punish or cave in to your daughter when she has a tantrum. If your mother's managers react internally to certain of her feelings—say, sadness—with impatience, denial, criticism, revulsion, or distraction, her managers will also react that way when you express sadness, and then your managers will pick up the same attitude. A child who hears *We do not boast in this family* will exile his proud part. A child who hears *We are strong in this family* will exile her weak parts. In this way, any feeling from sadness or anger to excitement and love can be exiled in families. Since feelings give us direction, banishing them not only causes us to lose contact with the parts who express such feelings, it also puts us at risk of feeling empty and directionless.

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A PERSONAL BURDEN AND A LEGACY BURDEN

The most fundamental and common burdens, such as *I am worthless*, *I am too much*, *I am unlovable*, tend to develop in response to firsthand experience. When a child is shamed, terrorized, or in some

other way injured, the child's system may take that experience in as factual information about himself. For example, let's say an older sibling discovers that shaming is an effective way of exerting control over a younger sibling and repeatedly shames the younger one for being excited. In turn, the younger one's protectors observe that being "too much" has bad consequences, and they set about banishing the excited part internally. When we suggest helping the excited part in therapy, those protectors get nervous. They need reassurance before they will give up their fear of being too much, and ultimately they need to observe the Self reversing the verdict of shaming by loving and valuing the excited part.

Any burden may be personal. On the other hand, it may be a legacy burden that has been visited on all the children in a family by one or both parents; for example, regarding the family's home culture, *People in this family don't do things by half measures!*, or regarding the larger culture, *We are an independent people!* Legacy burdens are communicated firsthand from parent to child, but are secondhand in the sense that the origin of the belief (the reason that having a particular need or desire is a threat) comes from the experience of someone else, someone who might have lived generations earlier (Sinko, 2016).

Epigenetics, a process by which trauma is transferred across generations through the genes of a traumatized person or animal, may prove to be a potent factor in the transmission of legacy burdens. Epigenetic studies are indicating a relationship between environmental stressors that induce a genetic change called *methylation* and conditions such as asthma, bipolar disorder, and schizophrenia. A recent study on epigenetic influence found that the sons of Union soldiers who had been prisoners during the Civil War (a traumatically mistreated population) tended to die younger than sons of Union soldiers who had not been imprisoned during the war (Khazan, 2018). Discoveries like these raise the question of how we may be able to exert influence in a positive rather than negative direction. It remains to be explored if therapy, for example, could reduce the level of methylation of stress-related genes.

Even when we have no clue as to the origins of our inherited beliefs and anachronistic emotions, such burdens can be powerful life organizers. For example, a woman who wonders why she has trouble with romantic relationships may have inherited an unconscious belief that all men are dangerous because of the gang rape experienced by a great-grandmother during wartime. Legacy burdens can be found in chronic, shared feeling states (*My mom was anxious, too*), shared habits (*In my family, we always joke when we're scared*), and shared beliefs (*I learned not to question authority*). When someone expresses bias or fear about a class of people (regarding, say, their gender, sexual orientation, sexual identity, race, or ethnicity), or about a particular feeling (e.g., shame, anger, grief,

excitement, love) or behavior (e.g., intimacy, self-assertion, generosity, adventurousness), we are often hearing a legacy burden. Legacy burdens are stocked with family history and can go back many generations (Sinko, 2016).

When we want to find out if a burden is a legacy or personal, we ask the part, “What percent of this belief (feeling, behavior, etc.) belongs to someone else?” Although the answer can range from 100% to zero, it is often greater than 50%. We follow with another question, “Would the part or parts who carry this burden for you be willing to let go of the percentage that doesn’t belong to you?” When they are ready to let go, the [unburdening](#) can be accomplished quickly. Sometimes, however, a part (or a cluster of parts) is reluctant to let go of a legacy burden. The most salient sticking points tend to be loyalty to family, ethnic group, or country; the belief that the burden is the only way to stay connected to someone important; or the belief that someone they love will have to carry it if the part lets it go. Whatever the reason, we explore concerns about a legacy burden as we would explore them about a personal burden (Sinko, 2016).

LEONARD’S LEGACY BURDENS

Leonard was a gay 19-year-old who had inherited various legacy burdens: his father’s striving, perfectionism, and shame about (Leonard suspected) being gay; his mother’s obsession with looks; and his parents’ shared disdain for his sad parts, all of which came from the parents’ families of origin. Leonard also had personal burdens, including feeling responsible for his parents’ happiness and believing that he was weak and repulsive. In therapy he discovered that he could not do much about his personal burdens until he had found and released his legacy burdens. His mother had seemed depressed throughout his childhood, and even though he had parts who believed she would never be happy, he also had a part who felt guilty and tried to carry this burden for her.

Additionally, Leonard had parts who felt angry that he worried so much about his parents. Before his junior year in high school these burdens inspired his managers to try to please his parents, but during junior year an angry part began to take over. He got a fake ID to go to gay clubs, where he drank too much and had unprotected sex. When Leonard came to therapy, he hated himself for being conflicted and unhappy about being gay because he believed that he ought to feel comfortable and happy. Learning from his parts that 60% of the oppressive sense of being stifled and inadequate stemmed from legacy burdens expedited Leonard’s therapy. Once the legacy burdens were gone, he found that he could differentiate from his parents more kindly, which made him feel more confident and hopeful as he turned to his personal burdens.

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PERSONAL BURDENS

As we illustrate throughout this book, in addition to family dynamics and cultural bias, any personal experience of being rejected, abandoned, shocked, scared, or abused (physically, sexually, or emotionally) can burden our most sensitive parts with fear, shame, and emotional pain. Exiles routinely cite one or more of a few comprehensively condemning beliefs about their value. At the top of the list are worthlessness, unlovability, and being too much or too little. Less often but still not infrequently, young parts come to believe they are bad or evil. As well, trauma can burden our protectors with disdain for vulnerability and extreme beliefs about certain categories of people or the world in general. In all cases, inner and outer children have a developmental tendency to translate experience into identity: *I am not loved* becomes *I am unlovable*, and *a bad thing happened* becomes *I am bad*.

The Exile's Need for Redemption

When a child has reason to be pessimistic about their value, the normal need for approval escalates to craving. Such children are vigilant about messages regarding their worth and vulnerable to the negative judgment of anyone on whom they depend. Striving to lift the curse of unlovability, these young parts influence otherwise sensible adults to return to people who have hurt them or to find a close substitute, which is likely to result in a string of unsatisfying, dangerous relationships.

Leonard's Personal Burdens

Let's go back to Leonard. Even if he had never suffered any more intense trauma, his family culture would have encouraged him to exile his sensitive, lonely, and angry parts. But Leonard did experience trauma. As his therapy proceeded, his injured parts began to show him where they were frozen in the past. First came the 5-year-old whose mother had disappeared one day. Later in life Leonard learned that his mother had been hospitalized for a "nervous breakdown" when he was 5. At the time, however, his mother simply disappeared. He woke up alone and could not find her in the house. He finally found his father, who would give no answer as to her whereabouts. When his grandmother, who was not a nurturing woman, showed up that afternoon to take care of him, she, too, was silent when he asked about his mother. The 5-year-old concluded, as children will, that he must be the cause of her disappearance in some literally unspeakable way. Over the course of her month-long absence, Leonard withdrew in a state of fear and guilt, telling himself scary and soothing

stories in turn. Later, when his mother finally returned and the adults continued to act as if nothing had happened, he got angry, which evoked managers in the adults who scolded and silenced him.

After Leonard helped the 5-year-old in therapy, another part, a 7-year-old, appeared with another traumatic story. A teenage cousin had tricked Leonard into going into the woods, where he had pressured Leonard to touch and play with his penis. Leonard had wanted to tell his parents but his managers, who viewed his parents as too fragile to hear stressful news, had shamed him into silence. After helping the 7-year-old, Leonard heard from more parts about other scary experiences all the way through his 20s. Since his managers had left wounded parts in the past and moved the rest of his system forward, Leonard needed to retrieve and help each one to unburden and heal (a process we describe in detail later).

THE BURDENS OF PROTECTORS

Protectors have burdens, too. First, they believe the negative press about the exiles; second, their jobs are burdensome. One of the terrible ironies of emotional abandonment and abuse is that a child's protective parts mimic abusers, be they adults or other children. Approval-seeking managers and reactive firefighters are capable of repeating, internally, virtually any extreme behavior that has been perpetrated on a child, from perfectionism, criticism, and moralizing to physical attack, all in the mistaken hope that a perfect (or punished) child will be better loved. The job of mimicking a perpetrator is, of course, nasty and makes the part unpopular in the system. Protectors need our help to let go of the extreme parental energies that constitute legacy burdens.

Like all protectors, Leonard's were also burdened with various beliefs about him (really about Leonard as a child): that he was overly sensitive and excitable; his feet were too big; his needs were a burden to others, especially his parents; and his anger was a repulsive sign of selfishness. Their jobs ranged from inhibition (*Don't speak, don't complain, don't get angry*) to distraction (*Drink, have sex, tune out*), and their aims were to hide his faults, punish him for failing, make him acceptable, and distract him from feeling miserable.

BURDENS, SYMPTOM SEVERITY, AND LENGTH OF TREATMENT

The length and difficulty of treatment in IFS are governed not by symptom severity but by degree of inner polarization, distrust in Self-leadership, and the client's level of burdening. As we have explained, parts are forced into extreme roles in a few ways: They protect exiles proactively (managers) or reactively (firefighters), they polarize each other, and they are frozen in a frightening

time in the past (both protectors and exiles). Because most people are socialized to exile various of their own parts, even people who were never severely hurt will be organized according to this manager, exile, firefighter triad, and the client's symptoms tell us which group dominates. For example, managers tend to dominate in people who are chronically depressed, firefighters in people who are prone to impulsive behaviors, and exiles in those who experience acute anxiety, fear, sadness, and loneliness. When exiles are highly burdened, therapy takes longer because protectors are more extreme and polarized, and the system has little trust in the client's Self. We keep in mind that protectors are burdened too, but are unlikely to release their burdens until the exiles they protect have been healed (unburdened) and the system is less vulnerable.

CONCLUSION

Parts are often mistaken for their burdens, which causes a great deal of harm. While protectors exile vulnerable parts, well-meaning relatives, friends, and treaters battle dangerous protectors—and no one wins. Parts are not their burdens. When we know this clearly, we can reassure fearful parts that we have no hidden agenda that would involve purging or killing off any part of the inner system. This news, in itself, immediately alters the dynamic of a polarized system, which has been relying on the idea that excising someone is the only possible cure for the condition of being unacceptable. We want protectors to get the message that it will benefit the larger system for everyone to be liberated and for those who want a new, preferred role to get one. We aim for everyone to feel welcome.

Burdens develop in many ways: vertically between generations in a family or due to the behavior of other influential authority figures such as teachers, coaches, or priests. Burdens can also develop at the hands of strangers, horizontally with siblings and peers, or by chance of nature (fires, earthquakes, tsunamis, floods, etc.). Legacy burdens develop in families and can back go many generations. Personal burdens develop in response to events that are personally traumatic. When a child is injured, the qualities for which she was attacked or that she believes got her in trouble are viewed by the internal system as a liability, so parts who lead with those qualities (e.g., naiveté, sweetness, spontaneity, excitement, courage, anger, sadness, frustration, sensitivity, compassion) will be banished, which makes those parts feel unwanted and desperate. From their place of exile, they long for rescue and redemption. Meanwhile, protectors are constrained by what they believe about exiled parts. All in all, the burdened system is a portrait of restriction, constraint, rebellion, and frustration. And this is the way most of us expend most of our energy.

The good news is that all this can change. Burdens can be released and parts who are liberated can transform. Later in this book we illustrate how parts unburden themselves. We are aware that this will seem impossible to many readers—too good to be true—and we understand this skepticism. Skeptical parts are welcome. In our experience, once skeptical parts believe their safety concerns can be effectively addressed, they are usually willing to try something new.